

Ryan McPherson, RHP, Mississippi State

2026 Stats: 3.56 ERA/43 IP/1.163 WHIP/51 K/13 BB/3.92 K:BB

6-3, 205

Metrics

FB: 96.2/17.8 IVB/11.7 HB/-4.52 VAA/6 ext/6.1 relH/41.4% zone/51.7 AA/49.6% usage/2230 rpm

CT: 89.7/5.5 IVB/-0.3 HB/-6.58 VAA/24.4% zone/44.2 AA/6.3% usage/2390 rpm

CB: 84/-10.5 IVB/-8 HB/-8.97 VAA/35.2% zone/44.1 AA/18% usage/2400 rpm

SL: 86.4/0.5 IVB/-7.4 HB/-7.47 VAA/30.2% zone/40.8 AA/7.4% zone/2430 rpm

SPL: 88.4/4.4 IVB/12 HB/-7.29 VAA/26.3% zone/45.2 AA/18.7% zone/1130 rpm

Write-up

McPherson emerged as one of Mississippi State's best starters in 2026, pairing premium athleticism with one of the more complete five-pitch repertoires in the SEC. The delivery is fluid and repeatable, allowing him to create plus arm speed without excessive effort while consistently filling the strike zone. A tight arm circle behind the body and hard 1B set up creates some deception as well. His arsenal is anchored by a lively four-seam fastball and a quality splitter, while three distinct breaking balls give him multiple ways to attack hitters. The overall profile already fits comfortably in a professional rotation, but the combination of strike throwing, athleticism, and the possibility of an above average fifth offering leaves the door open for a future starter if two of the breaking balls continue to develop. There is more polish here than the typical power starter, giving McPherson one of the safer floors among SEC arms.

The fastball combines above-average velocity with true riding life and enough arm-side movement to avoid becoming a purely vertical offering. Sitting comfortably in the mid-90s and reaching the upper-90s, the pitch consistently generated swing-and-miss at the top of the strike zone while still producing enough weak contact to play in hitter's counts. McPherson showed advanced feel for elevating against both handednesses, and nearly all of his fastball whiffs came above the belt where the riding life played best. The command is already solid, although occasional middle misses led to harder

contact than the overall traits would suggest. Continuing to improve glove-side command would allow the fastball to consistently play as an above-average professional offering. 50/55 pitch

The cutter serves primarily as a bridge between the fastball and breaking balls rather than a featured weapon. It carries firm velocity with short, late glove-side movement and enough depth to keep hitters from sitting exclusively on the four-seamer. McPherson showed flashes of quality command to the glove side, particularly against right-handed hitters, but the pitch remains inconsistent in both usage and finish, often backing up. With increased confidence and usage, it could become an effective contact-management pitch that helps protect the fastball rather than generating swings and misses on its own. It got elite whiff in its limited usage, but the lack of consistency in shape stifles the floor.

40/45+ pitch

The curveball is the softer of McPherson's two primary breaking balls and features true top-to-bottom shape with impressive depth. It consistently landed for strikes while generating uncomfortable swings beneath the zone when he finished it. He struggled to bury the CB with consistency, often using it more as a strike stealer. While it does not currently possess elite bat-missing ability with its current command profile, the shape is clean, the command is ahead of the slider, and the overall profile projects comfortably as an average major league breaking ball capable of handling hitters from both sides. 45/50 pitch

The slider gives McPherson a harder breaking look with tighter velocity separation from the fastball. It shows quality depth with enough glove-side movement to function as a legitimate put-away offering against right-handed hitters. The command is less consistent than the curveball, occasionally backing up or staying on plane, but when buried below the zone it generated empty swings at an above-average rate. The athleticism and spin characteristics suggest additional consistency is attainable, giving the slider room to grow into another above-average pitch. 45/50+ pitch

The splitter is the defining secondary in McPherson's arsenal. Thrown with excellent velocity separation and true late tumble, it consistently mirrored the fastball before disappearing beneath barrels. The pitch generated chase against both handednesses while producing soft ground-ball contact when hitters stayed on it. Unlike many collegiate splitters, McPherson already shows encouraging feel

for landing it below the strike zone rather than simply throwing it into the dirt. Continued refinement of the command and movement consistency gives the pitch a realistic path toward becoming a true plus major league splitter. This pitch, and its continued command gains, is the difference in if McPherson becomes a starter or high leverage arm in pro ball looks. 55/60 pitch